Some three months later, in March 1579, Akbar made Muzaffar Khan his governor in the east. A whole new set of commanders – or, more accurately, officials – went with him, including the refugee from Shia Iran, Hakim Abul Fath, whom Badauni accuses of pandering to Akbar's heresies and thus becoming his best friend. But that was not all. Not only did Akbar send a most finicky accountant, Muzaffar Khan, to govern the battle-weary, loot-hungry chiefs of Bengal, not only did he send a most provocative thinker, Abul Fath, who often went 'in advance of' Akbar's own heresies, to plague them, he also issued an imperial order: the amirs in Bengal should not presume to 'exceed'[16] their new governor's command.

It was not for the warlords of Bengal, however, to succumb, like Abdun Nabi and Makhdum-ul-Mulk, to a decree. By the spring of the following year, Muzaffar Khan's unwilling new subordinates had killed him.

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It would be an understatement to say that Akbar's pet mansabdari reforms were unpopular. His milk brother Aziz, the only man who had been allowed to hunt with Akbar in that first, grand qamargah in Lahore, who had ridden in Akbar's howdah in the battle against the Uzbek brothers, who was the son of Shamsuddin and Jiji, the quasi-parents that had cared for the emperor when he was an infant howling in the dark – his milk brother and closest friend, that is – hated the reforms. In October 1575, the year that Akbar inaugurated both his Ibadat Khana and his new administration, the emperor invited Aziz to court, planning to put him in charge of branding his mansabdars' horses.

Branding, or '*dagh*', was as much a part of the mansabdari plan as the appropriation of semi-independent fiefs. Unlike the warlords of old, whose loyalty to monarchs like Humayun was calculated with one eye firmly on political advantage and material gain, mansabdars would be ranked and paid according to the number of soldiers and horses they maintained, and would be expected to produce them on order, not inclination. To prevent any possible, and predictable, corruption of the system – soldiers and horses paraded on hire, basically – Akbar had reintroduced the system of dagh, devised by Alauddin Khilji and used more recently by Sher Shah Suri, by which his mansabdars' horses would be branded and therefore easily, and